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Department of Economics

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Teaching Statement

I come from a family of teachers. My grandmother was a teacher and school principal, and she devoted her whole career to schools in disadvantaged neighborhoods. An aunt and several cousins also followed the teaching path, in elementary and middle schools. Growing up, I heard a lot about their experiences in the classroom, and I took from them the idea that good teaching is a job accomplished through consistency and patience. I also believe that students learn by being at the center of the action and doing the work themselves. My role is to make it possible for them to do that work, and to be available to guide them when they get stuck. I have been a teaching assistant at Cornell for four semesters, and in 2023 I received the Anindya Majumder ’98 Memorial Prize for Excellence in Teaching for my first semester teaching ECON 3140.

I was the only teaching assistant for ECON 3140, Introduction to Econometrics, for three consecutive springs (2023, 2024, and 2025), and being the sole TA gave me the opportunity to design my weekly sections and all accompanying materials. My sections would start with a handwritten handout summarizing the main results of the week, with the important steps left blank, and the first part of the section would be spent filling in the blanks together. We would then move to problems from past problem sets or prelims. I let students try them first and solve them at the board only after they had the opportunity to struggle with the material for a bit, which meant the discussion focused on where students got stuck. For a few topics I also wrote short R notebooks with simulations, for example one where students check that the Frisch–Waugh–Lovell theorem holds visually before they had to use it. These notebooks were meant to provide visual learning and some coding basics, but mostly to bring in real-world applications, for example estimating how much race matters in predicting whether a mortgage application is approved.

Having taught the course three times, I was able to revise the materials every year based on what students said. The handouts, for example, started with a student who asked in 2023 for a written summary of each section. Perfecting the materials also meant perfecting the way I framed problems and explained content. Students rated the sections 5.0 out of 5 overall in 2023 and 2024 and 4.25 in 2025. One student described the most valued part of the sections as a “review of lecture material at the pace of students, with students able to ask questions throughout,” which was exactly my goal.

In the fall of 2024 I was a teaching assistant for ECON 3130, Introduction to Probability and Statistics, taught by Doug McKee, a senior lecturer who leads the department’s Active Learning Initiative and has written extensively on what makes teaching effective. The course is run as an active classroom, and so were the sections. Students spent most of the time working on problems in small groups of three or four. I would walk around and help individually, and at the end I would go over the solutions on the board. I learned a great deal from Doug. He treats teaching as a science, something to study and improve: much of his research is precisely on how people learn, he is constantly trying things in and outside of class, and he collects data to check whether they worked. Many of his lessons stayed with me, above all his kind and empathetic approach to students. Among the more practical ones, I highlight two favorites: the invention activity, where students get a problem they cannot yet solve with the tools they have, struggle with it for a while, and only then are taught the method; and the more general, subtle art of not explaining something until students have really tried, and of steering them with sub-questions they can answer rather than rushing to explain the whole problem. Running two flipped sections of thirty-six students each was also my first experience with the hard part of this format. One has to decide how long to let groups work before bringing everyone back. Students rated the sections 4.29 out of 5 overall, with forty-nine responses. Several comments were

about the atmosphere, for example: “I felt like we were encouraged to try to answer questions even if we got them wrong.”

I have also done some mentoring outside the classroom. An undergraduate who was in the first section I taught later became a research assistant on the same project as me. Over the next years, I helped her, beyond her tasks, with understanding the challenging concepts behind the project, organizing her work, and building a working relationship with our advisor. She graduated in 2025, and the note she left me is among the things I cherish the most from graduate school. I have had similar conversations, mostly about careers, with a pre-doctoral researcher in the department. As president of the Economics Graduate Student Association in 2023–24, I worked to make the department a place where every graduate student felt safe and supported.

I am qualified to teach econometrics at the undergraduate and graduate levels, as well as probability and statistics, and I am comfortable teaching in R and Python. If there is room, I would be happy to teach electives on causal inference and on causal inference with machine learning, and I could offer an elective on robustness and sensitivity analysis drawing on my own research.